iGaming News Today: New Site Check and Fix List

Site checked: https://wheat-bear-950363.hostingersite.com/ | Checked on 16 October 2026 | Compared page by page against the live igamingnewstoday.com

This site is for testing only. It must not go live or be indexed until every item in sections 1 to 4 is closed. Section 7 lists the same kind of problems on the live igamingnewstoday.com, for the same developer. New domain: igamingnewstoday.co (a separate new site; igamingnewstoday.com stays as it is). Articles are not part of this round; they will be planned separately.

Short verdict

- The structure is right: all 13 pages, all 8 category slugs and the /%category%/%postname%/ URL format match the live site exactly, and there are 0 links pointing back to the live domain.
- Every HTML page carries noindex, nofollow (170 of 170 pages, checked twice on 16 October). No page from this site was found in search results on 16 October.
- But the site is still public, it shares the live site's Google Analytics, Tag Manager and AdSense codes, and it was built from an OLD copy of the live site (late September), so every change made on live in October is missing.
- Email addresses were rewritten to @wheat-bear-950363.hostingersite.com by the search and replace.
- Hidden files: the full theme node_modules folder (175 packages) and the theme source files (package.json, package-lock.json, vite.config.js, README.md) are publicly downloadable. No malware, injected scripts or hidden spam links were found.

1. Safety: do these first (today)

#	Problem found	What to do
1.1	The whole site is public. Anyone with the link, and any crawler, can read every page, sitemap, feed and the REST API.	Password-protect the whole site: hPanel > this website > Advanced > Password Protect Directories, directory "/". This is the same method already used on our two old clones (374688 and 319120). Keep noindex on as a second layer.
1.2	robots.txt blocks ONLY Googlebot. Every other bot (Bing, ChatGPT, Perplexity, Claude and others) is allowed in. Blocking Googlebot also stops Google from seeing	Once 1.1 is done this is covered. Do not rely on robots.txt for a staging site.

	the noindex tag, so a linked URL can still appear in Google without content.	
1.3	Public sitemaps list staging URLs: sitemap_index.xml, post, page, events, directory, category sitemaps and news-sitemap.xml. /feed/ and /comments/feed/ are also open and have no noindex.	Covered by 1.1. Also turn off the Rank Math sitemap module on staging if possible.
1.4	llms.txt is live on staging and lists staging URLs for AI crawlers.	Covered by 1.1. Disable llms.txt on staging.
1.5	Staging uses the SAME tracking codes as the live site: GA4 G-J4J298DFG5, GTM-PG5RJFCQ and AdSense ca-pub-4237062840058088. Every staging visit (team, bots, testing) is counted in live Analytics, and AdSense ads load on a domain that is not approved.	Remove or disable GA4, GTM and AdSense on staging. Disconnect Site Kit on staging so it cannot write to the live Search Console or Analytics.
1.6	Theme build files are public: /wp-content/themes/newstoday/package.json and vite.config.js return 200. On live these were already moved out (they return 404).	Move the build files out of the public theme folder, the same as was done on live.
1.7	/wp-json/wp/v2/users publicly lists the usernames eva and ignt-admin. /readme.html is also open.	Covered by 1.1 for staging. Fix the same on the final site: block the users endpoint for logged-out visitors and remove readme.html.

2. Hidden files and leftovers that should not be on the server

Checked on 16 October 2026 by requesting about 120 known sensitive paths, plugin and theme folders, and every page source. A 404 means the file is not there; 403 means it is there but blocked.

#	Found	What to do
2.1	The theme node_modules folder is on the server and its files download publicly, e.g. /wp-content/themes/newstoday/node_modules/vite/package.json returns 200 (175 packages). On live this returns 404.	Delete node_modules from the server. It is only needed on the developer's own machine to build the theme.
2.2	Theme source and build files are public: package.json, package-lock.json, vite.config.js, README.md (all 200). Live returns 404 for these four.	Remove them from the server, the same as was done on live on 2 October.
2.3	The theme .gitignore is public on both staging and live. (The server listing confirms there is no .git folder on staging.)	Remove .gitignore from the server on both

		sites. Deploy built files only.
2.4	The theme style.css header still says "Theme URI: example.com/newstoday, Author: Your Name". Same on live.	Put the real theme name and owner (iGaming News Today) in the header.
2.5	3 unused default themes are installed: Twenty Twenty-Five, Twenty Twenty-Four, Twenty Twenty-Three. Same on live.	Keep one default theme as a fallback and delete the other two.
2.6	Public WordPress files that reveal the version or are not used: readme.html, license.txt, wp-links-opml.php. Same on live.	Block or remove on the final site.
2.7	Staging copies every live tracking and verification code: GA4, GTM, Google Ads AW-17533223914, AdSense, two Meta Pixels (1269233924519755 and 2281243268977317), Microsoft Clarity, and the live Google, Bing and Pinterest verification tags.	Remove all of these from staging. On igamingnewstoday.co, decide with Sumit whether the new site gets its own Analytics, Pixel and Clarity, and add fresh verification tags for the new domain.
2.8	Contact Form 7, Mailchimp for WP and WP Mail SMTP are active on staging, copied from live. Not checked from inside wp-admin, so unconfirmed, but if they keep the live settings, a test form or newsletter sign-up on staging goes into the live Mailchimp list and live mailbox.	Point the forms to a test mailbox and disconnect Mailchimp on staging.
2.9	The Instant Indexing plugin (fast-indexing-api) is installed. On live it auto-submits pages to the Google Indexing API with a service-account key. On staging it could submit staging URLs to Google under our live account.	Turn it off on staging. Do not reuse the live service-account key on the new site.
2.10	Only 2 of the 5 live authors exist on staging (Eva Carter and the team account). Harpreet, Nikita and Neeva are missing. 1,225 media files vs 2,642 on live.	Create the author accounts before any article move, so articles keep the right bylines. Copy the full media library.

Checked and clean: no wp-config backups, no .env, no SQL or ZIP backups, no phpinfo or test files, no debug.log or error_log, no migration-plugin backup folders, no directory listings (folders return blank or 403). No eval, encoded scripts, hidden spam links or unknown external scripts on any of the 172 pages: every external script is Google, AddToAny or Meta, and every external link goes to our own sites, social profiles, help charities or regulators. LiteSpeed Cache and AI Engine are gone. All hidden page elements are normal search and form parts of the theme.

2B. Server check inside Hostinger (read-only, 16 October 2026)

Checked in hPanel and the File Manager for this website. Nothing was changed.

#	Found on the server	What to do
S.1	Security warnings from Hostinger (Patchstack): Rank Math SEO 1.0.279 has open issues fixed in 1.0.280 (SQL injection, file upload, file deletion). WP Rocket 3.20.4 has issues fixed in 3.21.1 and 3.23.5. The LIVE site runs the same two versions.	Update both on staging first and test. Updates on live only after Sumit approves.
S.2	Smart auto-updates are ON for staging (Hostinger mu-plugin hostinger-auto-updates.php, daily update log). Live updates are on hold, so staging and live will drift apart.	Decide with Sumit: keep auto-updates on staging for testing, or match live. Note what version is on each before the move.
S.3	/.ftp-deploy-sync-state.json (135 KB, from GitHub FTP-Deploy-Action) is publicly downloadable. It lists 557 server file paths with hashes. The same file is public on LIVE too.	Block it with .htaccess on both sites, or exclude it from the public folder.
S.4	Mac .DS_Store files were uploaded by the deploy: /wp-content/.DS_Store and /wp-content/themes/.DS_Store are public (they list folder contents). Same on LIVE.	Delete them and add .DS_Store to the deploy exclude list.
S.5	The deploy sends the whole WordPress folder, including node_modules and source files (see 2.1 and 2.2), plus QUICKSTART.md and screenshot.txt in the theme (both public).	Deploy only the built theme files. Add an exclude list to the FTP-Deploy-Action workflow.
S.6	Leftovers from old plugins: /wp-content/litespeed/ folder and the LSCACHE blocks in .htaccess (LiteSpeed Cache is no longer installed), /wp-content/uploads/mwai_VF34vRDO.log (AI Engine, public, empty), /wp-content/uploads/wpseo-redirects/ (Yoast), empty upgrade-temp-backup folder, and .htaccess.bk.	Remove them after a backup.
S.7	WP Rocket config copied from live: /wp-content/uploads/wp-rocket-config/igamingnewstoday.com.php sits next to the staging one.	Remove the live-domain config from staging, and regenerate WP Rocket config on the final domain.
S.8	Extra plugin on staging only: DX Delete Attached Media. When a post is deleted, it also deletes the images attached to it.	Fine for clearing the 70 test posts. Do not carry it to the final site: deleting one article could remove images used elsewhere.
S.9	Mailchimp for WP debug log (82 KB,	Delete it from staging.

	copied from live) is on the server. It is blocked from the public (403), but it may hold subscriber emails.	
S.10	wp-config.php still has commented-out database lines from local development. DISALLOW_FILE_EDIT is not set, so any admin can edit theme and plugin code from wp-admin.	Remove the old lines. Add define('DISALLOW_FILE_EDIT', true) on the final site once theme edits go through the deploy only.
S.11	Password protection is NOT set on this website (Advanced > Password Protect Directories is empty). Uploads use plain FTP on port 21.	Add password protection (see 1.1). Use SFTP or FTPS for deploys.

Checked and fine: Hostinger malware scanner reports no malware in the last 30 days; daily automatic backups are on (latest 14 October 2026, 21:45); no cron jobs; no Git connection in hPanel; WP_DEBUG is off; database prefix and security keys are set.

3. Built from an old copy: October work is missing

Page edit dates on staging stop at 28 September 2026 and the 70 test articles were imported on 30 September 2026. Everything below is already correct on the live site but missing here. Recommended fix: take a FRESH full copy of the live site (files + database) right before the switch, instead of patching this old copy. If you keep this copy, merge each item below.

#	Missing on staging	Live site has	How it was checked
3.1	Homepage "Key Coverage" block (8 category links + 4 latest interviews)	Present (page-templates/template-home.php)	Class kc-section: 0 on staging, 25 on live
3.2	Event structured data on event pages	Present (single-events.php)	"@type":"Event" on /event/ice-barcelona-2026/: 0 staging, 1 live
3.3	Footer still links to gambleaware.org	Footer links to our own /responsible-gambling/ page	Footer link list on homepage
3.4	Duplicate WebSite JSON-LD block still in header.php (2 JSON-LD blocks on every page)	Removed (1 block per page)	Counted on 166 pages
3.5	Old meta titles or descriptions on all 22 main pages (homepage, all 8 categories, About, Advertise, Contact, FAQ, Directory,	Updated titles and descriptions	Each page compared with live, side by side

	Directories, Events Calendar, Authors, 5 policy pages)		
3.6	Schema missing on 10 pages: Advertise, Cookies, Directory, Directories, Editorial Policy, Events Calendar, Our Authors, Privacy, Responsible Gambling, Terms only output BreadcrumbList	These pages also output Organization, WebPage, and CollectionPage where relevant. Homepage also has PostalAddress	Schema types compared per page
3.7	llms.txt is the Rank Math auto-generated version	Live llms.txt is hand-written	Opened both files
3.8	Sports Betting category H1 reads "Sports betting"	"Sports Betting"	H1 compared

4. Data problems in this copy

#	Problem found	What to do
4.1	The search and replace changed EMAIL ADDRESSES too. Pages now show info@, press@, marketing@, contact@, eva@, harpreet@, neeva@ and nikita@ wheat-bear-950363.hostingersite.com. Found on Homepage, Contact Us (also in its meta description), About Us, Advertise, FAQ (7 times) and Privacy Policy.	When moving to the new domain, exclude email addresses from the search and replace. They must stay @igamingnewstoday.com unless the same mailboxes are created on the new domain first and tested.
4.2	The 70 test articles all show a publish date of 30 September 2026 (17:57 to 17:58). Example: the Live! Casino Virginia article was published on live on 21 January 2026. The homepage shows these wrong dates to visitors.	Delete these 70 test posts before launch, or re-import with original publish dates, post IDs, authors and featured images kept. Articles will be planned separately.
4.3	10 links inside the test articles point to articles that were not imported, so they return 404 (for example /regions/uae-	Resolves itself once the full article set is moved. Re-run a broken link check after the article move.

	builds-gulfs-first-5b-casino/).	
4.4	4 images from September 2026 are missing in /wp-content/uploads/2026/09/: Light-Wonder-Webp.webp (homepage), Brightstar-Lottery-Webp.webp (Events), Florida-Gaming-Webp.webp (Legal and Compliance), igaming-partnership-webp.webp (Company News).	The uploads folder was copied incompletely. Copy the full uploads folder.
4.5	Company News, Finance and Marketing and Affiliates have 0 articles, so their pages are empty.	Fine for testing. Make sure no empty category goes live.

5. Open on both sites (fix in the theme once)

- FAQ questions are not headings: they render as a span inside the accordion button, so the FAQ page has 0 H2 tags. Make each question an H2 or H3 inside the button.
- Footer brand name still reads "iGamingNewsToday" on every page (footer, span.brand-name). It should read "iGaming News Today".

6. Before pointing igamingnewstoday.co (checklist, do not start yet)

- Get written approval from Sumit before any DNS, domain or redirect change.
- Take a full backup of the live site (files + database) and keep it offline.
- Keep every URL and slug exactly the same. The URL structure is frozen; no category or permalink changes during the move.
- Run the domain search and replace with email addresses excluded (see 4.1), then check for any leftover "hostingersite" text.
- igamingnewstoday.co is registered at GoDaddy (since 9 March 2026) and currently parked there. Point DNS only after Sumit approves, and install SSL before removing the password.
- igamingnewstoday.com stays live. The same article must never sit on both domains: moving articles needs its own plan (which ones move, canonical or 301 redirect) agreed with Sumit first. Until then, no articles on .co.
- Add igamingnewstoday.co as a new property in Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools.
- Remove the password protection, set robots meta back to index, follow, replace robots.txt with the live version, and turn on the sitemaps and the hand-written llms.txt.
- Reconnect GA4, GTM, AdSense, Site Kit and Search Console to the final domain only. Purge WP Rocket and the Hostinger CDN.
- Send Sumit a list of what changed and a re-check before anything is announced.

7. Live site igamingnewstoday.com: please fix these too

Checked from outside on 16 October 2026 (no login, nothing changed). Rules for the live site: take a full backup first, change one thing at a time and check the live page after each, never change a published URL or slug, and tell Sumit before each change goes live.

#	Found on live	What to do
L.1	Rank Math SEO 1.0.279 is installed. Patchstack lists open issues fixed in 1.0.280: SQL injection, arbitrary file upload (CVSS 9.1) and file deletion.	Update to 1.0.280 or later on staging first, test, then on live. Highest priority on this list.
L.2	WP Rocket 3.20.4 is installed. Patchstack lists issues fixed in 3.21.1 (stored XSS) and 3.23.5 (broken access control, denial of service).	Update to 3.23.5 or later, staging first, then live. Purge the cache after.
L.3	/.ftp-deploy-sync-state.json is public (94 KB, lists 409 server file paths with hashes).	Block it in .htaccess (keep the file, the deploy needs it), or move the deploy state out of the public folder.
L.4	Mac .DS_Store files are public: /.DS_Store, /wp-content/.DS_Store, /wp-content/themes/.DS_Store. They list the folder contents.	Delete them, add .DS_Store to the deploy exclude list, and block .DS_Store in .htaccess.
L.5	Theme leftovers are public: /wp-content/themes/newstoday/.gitignore and screenshot.txt. The theme style.css header still says "Theme URI: example.com/newstoday, Author: Your Name".	Remove the two files from the server and put the real theme details in the header.
L.6	Old plugin leftovers: /wp-content/uploads/mwai_VF34vRDO.log (AI Engine, public), /wp-content/litespeed/ folder (LiteSpeed Cache is no longer installed) and /wp-content/uploads/wpseo-redirects/ (Yoast).	Remove after a backup.
L.7	3 unused default themes: Twenty Twenty-Five, Twenty Twenty-Four, Twenty Twenty-Three.	Keep one as a fallback, delete the other two.
L.8	readme.html, license.txt and wp-links-opml.php are public and show the WordPress version.	Block or remove.
L.9	/wp-json/wp/v2/users publicly lists all 5 usernames: eva, harpreet, ignt-admin, neeva-malik, nikita. Usernames are half of a login.	Block the users endpoint for logged-out visitors. Author pages and bylines keep working.
L.10	FAQ questions are not headings, and the footer brand name reads "iGamingNewsToday" (see section 5).	Fix in the theme once, for both sites.

8. What is already correct on staging (checked)

- All 13 pages exist with the same slugs and templates as live.
- All 8 category slugs match live; permalink format matches.
- 0 internal links point to the live domain (checked 604 links across 172 URLs).
- noindex, nofollow on every HTML page; xmlrpc.php blocked (405); .env, .git, debug.log and wp-config backups blocked (403).
- WordPress 6.8.11 and Site Kit 1.188.0 (newer than live 6.8.10 and 1.172.0). Homepage and menus render correctly.

How this was checked: every URL in the staging sitemaps plus every homepage link (172 URLs) was fetched and compared with the same path on igamingnewstoday.com; 604 internal links and images were status-checked; search-engine check by site: search on 16 October 2026.